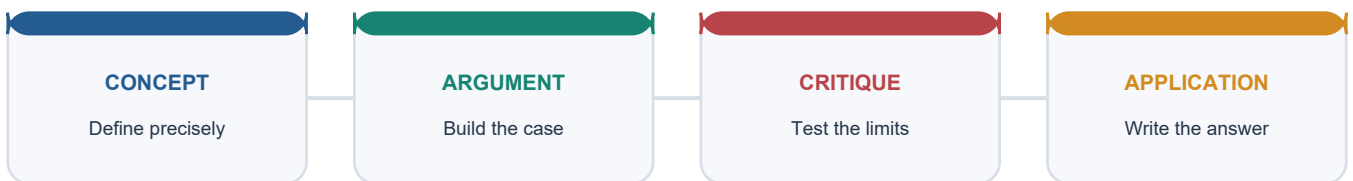


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

The Rig Vedic Age (Early Vedic): Solved Practice Workbook

Solved Practice Workbook

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

WORKBOOK CONTENTS

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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The Rig Vedic Age (Early Vedic): Solved Practice Workbook

Exact practice contract: 32 original hard MCQs appear before PYQs; keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 examiner traps are unique. Verified PYQs retain official/provisional-key discipline. Six original Mains models are independently word-counted.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Exact practice contract: These 32 questions appear before every PYQ. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times. All 128 option explanations and all 32 examiner traps are question-specific.

Q1

1 Which formulation best describes the Rig Veda as a historical source?

- A. A layered oral ritual-poetic corpus containing historical clues
- B. A territorial tax register arranged annually, without chronological or source qualification
- C. A neutral census of all social groups, as a direct material and social identity
- D. A continuous chronicle of one migration, throughout every region and textual layer

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: genre, layering and oral transmission are all preserved. [Q1-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: no annual territorial revenue register exists. [Q1-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: elite poetic visibility is not a social census. [Q1-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the corpus is not a single-event narrative. [Q1-D]

Examiner trap 1: Source value must be paired with genre and representativeness limits.

Q2

2 Which books are conventionally treated as the older Rigvedic family books?

- A. Books 1 and 10 only, without chronological or source qualification
- B. Books 2-7, as a direct material and social identity
- C. Books 8 and 9 only, throughout every region and textual layer
- D. All ten books as one layer, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: both books contain important later-arranged material. [Q2-A]
- **B:** Correct: Books 2-7 form the conventional family-book baseline. [Q2-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Book 9 is a Soma collection and Book 8 is not the family-book set. [Q2-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: relative layering prevents a single-layer treatment. [Q2-D]

Examiner trap 2: Family-book chronology is relative, not an exact calendar date.

Q3

3 The broad c. 1500/1200-1000 BCE range should be used as

- A. the exact date of every hymn, as a direct material and social identity
- B. proof that Late Harappan equals Rigvedic, throughout every region and textual layer

- C. a debated working horizon controlled by textual layers
- D. the fixed beginning of iron-based territorial monarchy

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: composition and arrangement occurred over time. [Q3-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: overlap permits contact but not cultural identity. [Q3-B]
- **C:** Correct: the range is a working frame, not a uniform stamp. [Q3-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: widespread iron and territorial monarchy belong mainly later. [Q3-D]

Examiner trap 3: A broad range cannot erase internal textual chronology.

Q4

4 Which river pair is securely matched?

- A. Parushni-Beas, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. Vipasha-Ravi, as a complete territorial institution
- C. Asikni-Jhelum, without chronological or source qualification
- D. Shutudri-Sutlej, as a direct material and social identity

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Parushni is associated with Ravi. [Q4-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Vipasha is associated with Beas. [Q4-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Asikni is associated with Chenab. [Q4-C]
- **D:** Correct: Shutudri is the Sutlej. [Q4-D]

Examiner trap 4: Close river options are defeated by memorising the Punjab sequence.

Q5

5 Sapta-Sindhu is best understood as

- A. a flexible north-western river-cultural horizon
- B. a surveyed seven-district kingdom, without chronological or source qualification
- C. the whole Ganga plain under one ruler, as a direct material and social identity
- D. a synonym for the Mature Harappan state, throughout every region and textual layer

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: it identifies a broad remembered river world. [Q5-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the expression is not an administrative survey. [Q5-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the eastern Ganga focus is later. [Q5-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: textual geography cannot be equated with Harappan polity. [Q5-D]

Examiner trap 5: Do not turn poetic geography into a bounded territorial state.

Q6

6 In an older Rigvedic context, grama can denote

- A. only a revenue village, without chronological or source qualification
- B. a moving, fighting or kin group, as a direct material and social identity
- C. a four-varna council, throughout every region and textual layer

- D. an iron-smelting town, as a complete territorial institution, without chronological or source qualification

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the later settled-village meaning is not universal. [Q6-A]
- **B:** Correct: mobile and martial group senses are contextually important. [Q6-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: grama is not a varna institution. [Q6-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the term does not identify an iron urban centre. [Q6-D]

Examiner trap 6: Historical semantics controls translation; dictionary familiarity does not.

Q7

7 The Rigvedic rajan is most safely described as

- A. an elected modern president, as a direct material and social identity
- B. an emperor with provincial governors, throughout every region and textual layer
- C. a kin-based chief and ritual patron, as a complete territorial institution
- D. a salaried tax collector, without chronological or source qualification

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: modern electoral categories are anachronistic. [Q7-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: a provincial bureaucracy is not securely attested. [Q7-B]
- **C:** Correct: protection, warfare, ritual and redistribution define the role. [Q7-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: revenue collection does not exhaust chiefly authority. [Q7-D]

Examiner trap 7: Real authority need not equal mature territorial monarchy.

Q8

8 Which office-role pair is correctly matched?

- A. Purohita-permanent cavalry commander, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. Senani-chief tax assessor, as a complete territorial institution
- C. Gramani-temple-image superintendent, without chronological or source qualification
- D. Purohita-priestly adviser and ritual supporter

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the purohita's defining role was priestly-political counsel. [Q8-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: senani is connected with military leadership. [Q8-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: no temple-image bureaucracy defines the office. [Q8-C]
- **D:** Correct: ritual counsel and political support fit the purohita. [Q8-D]

Examiner trap 8: Functional titles show specialisation without proving ministries.

Q9

9 Which statement about sabha, samiti and vidatha is safest?

- A. They indicate collective arenas with uncertain membership
- B. They were identical houses of a bicameral parliament
- C. They prove universal adult suffrage, as a direct material and social identity
- D. They excluded all ritual and distributive functions

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: plurality and uncertainty must be preserved. [Q9-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: modern bicameral identity is invented. [Q9-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: no universal franchise is demonstrated. [Q9-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: vidatha especially has ritual and distributive associations. [Q9-D]

Examiner trap 9: Participation is not the same claim as modern democracy.

Q10

10 Vidatha is commonly treated as

- A. a regular land-revenue office, without chronological or source qualification
- B. a multifunctional ritual-military-distributive gathering
- C. a hereditary artisan guild, throughout every region and textual layer
- D. a permanent walled capital, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: assessed fiscal administration is not its meaning. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: its functions vary across ritual, military and social contexts. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: occupational guild structure is not established. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: a gathering is not a capital city. [Q10-D]

Examiner trap 10: Do not flatten changing textual functions into one modern institution.

Q11

11 The Battle of Ten Kings is associated with

- A. Janaka on the Ganga, as a direct material and social identity, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. Ajatashatru at Rajagriha, throughout every region and textual layer
- C. Sudas of the Bharatas near Parushni, as a complete territorial institution
- D. Ashoka on the Indus, without chronological or source qualification

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Janaka belongs to a later Vedic-Upanishadic setting. [Q11-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Ajatashatru belongs to the mahajanapada age. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct: Book 7 praises Sudas in the Parushni conflict. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Ashoka is Mauryan and much later. [Q11-D]

Examiner trap 11: Named memory must still be qualified as patronage-shaped victory poetry.

Q12

12 Dasa and dasyu should be interpreted as

- A. one securely identified archaeological culture
- B. a fixed skin-colour census, as a complete territorial institution
- C. all speakers of one non-Indo-Aryan language, without chronological or source qualification
- D. contextual political, ritual, social or mythic opponents

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: pottery or burial assemblages do not equal textual labels. [Q12-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: the terms do not supply biological classification. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: linguistic identity cannot be universalised from the labels. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: meanings shift with passage and relationship. [Q12-D]

Examiner trap 12: Reject racial simplification without denying conflict or subordination.

Q13

13 Gavishti most directly helps connect

- A. cattle wealth with search, raid and conflict, as a complete territorial institution
- B. iron smelting with tax collection, without chronological or source qualification
- C. temple building with image worship, as a direct material and social identity
- D. urban guilds with coin minting, throughout every region and textual layer, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: cattle and warfare meet in this diagnostic vocabulary. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: neither iron nor tax administration is implied. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: monumental temple worship is not the relevant setting. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: guild and mint structures are later projections. [Q13-D]

Examiner trap 13: One term can reveal an economic-political mechanism, not a complete economy.

Q14

14 Pastoral predominance means that

- A. agriculture was unknown, without chronological or source qualification
- B. cattle-centred values coexisted with cultivation and crafts
- C. every community migrated continuously, throughout every region and textual layer
- D. land revenue financed a bureaucracy, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: ploughing, yava, wells and harvesting are attested. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: relative cattle emphasis fits the mixed economy. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: mobility varied and settlement existed. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: regular fiscal bureaucracy is not securely attested. [Q14-D]

Examiner trap 14: Predominance is a statement of relative weight, not exclusivity.

Q15

15 Which statement about bali is most accurate for the Early Vedic context?

- A. It was a struck silver coin, as a direct material and social identity
- B. It was a compulsory cadastral land tax, throughout every region and textual layer
- C. It was an offering or tribute rather than a mature regular tax
- D. It was a temple-entry fee, without chronological or source qualification

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: bali is not a coin denomination. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: assessed cadastral taxation is anachronistic. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: customary offering or tribute fits limited chiefship. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: temple institutions do not define the context. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: Fiscal vocabulary must be scaled to the political formation.

Q16

16 Nishka should not automatically be called a coin because it was

- A. a permanent tax district, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. a type of assembly, as a complete territorial institution, without chronological or source qualification
- C. a ploughing ritual, without chronological or source qualification
- D. a valuable metal object or ornament, as a direct material and social identity

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: nishka is not territorial administration. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: it is not a deliberative body. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: it is not the name of the plough. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: value does not prove standard struck coinage. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Valuable metal and monetised currency are distinct claims.

Q17

17 Which description best fits the Early Vedic household?

- A. A productive kin unit within a patriarchal tendency
- B. A state-run collective farm, without chronological or source qualification
- C. A monastery governed by a sangha, as a direct material and social identity
- D. An urban craft corporation, throughout every region and textual layer

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: household, kinship, production and unequal authority intersect. [Q17-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: state collectivisation is unsupported. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Buddhist monastic institutions are later. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: guild-like urban corporations are not the baseline. [Q17-D]

Examiner trap 17: Household analysis must combine economy, kinship and gender.

Q18

18 Named female-seer traditions demonstrate

- A. universal matriliney, without chronological or source qualification
- B. female visibility without proving complete equality
- C. absence of son preference, throughout every region and textual layer
- D. automatic membership in every assembly, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: patrilineal tendencies remain visible. [Q18-A]

- **B:** Correct: Ghosha or Lopamudra can qualify, not erase, patriarchy. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: textual valuation of sons persists. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: assembly participation cannot be universalised. [Q18-D]

Examiner trap 18: A visible exceptional or elite voice is not a social census.

Q19

19 The fourfold social scheme is most clearly articulated in

- A. the Nadi-stuti, as a direct material and social identity, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. the Nasadiya Sukta, throughout every region and textual layer
- C. the Purusha Sukta, Rig Veda 10.90, as a complete territorial institution
- D. the Arthashastra, without chronological or source qualification

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the river hymn maps poetic geography. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Nasadiya questions creation. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: 10.90 names Brahmana, Rajanya, Vaishya and Shudra. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the Arthashastra is a much later statecraft text. [Q19-D]

Examiner trap 19: The named hymn must always carry its generally later Book 10 qualification.

Q20

20 What follows most safely from the Purusha Sukta?

- A. Untouchability was fully institutionalised, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. Every occupation was hereditary, as a complete territorial institution
- C. All older family books contain the same scheme, without chronological or source qualification
- D. A fourfold ideology was articulated without proving later caste rigidity

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the hymn does not establish untouchability as a complete system. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: occupational closure cannot be inferred across society. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the scheme's Book 10 location matters. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: ideology and social implementation must be distinguished. [Q20-D]

Examiner trap 20: Do not use a cosmic norm as transparent evidence of universal practice.

Q21

21 Which deity-function pair is correctly matched?

- A. Agni-sacrificial mediation, as a complete territorial institution
- B. Varuna-only chariot manufacture, without chronological or source qualification
- C. Ushas-land-tax collection, as a direct material and social identity
- D. Soma-territorial surveying, throughout every region and textual layer

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Agni carries offerings and links humans with deities. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Varuna is associated with order and sovereignty. [Q21-B]

- **C:** Incorrect: Ushas personifies dawn and renewal. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Soma is ritual drink, deity and inspiration. [Q21-D]

Examiner trap 21: Deity questions test functional associations, not later institutional roles.

Q22

22 Rta is best understood as

- A. a codified penal statute, without chronological or source qualification
- B. cosmic-ritual-moral order and regularity, as a direct material and social identity
- C. a coin standard, throughout every region and textual layer, as a complete territorial institution
- D. a territorial infantry unit, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: rta is wider and less juridically codified. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: truth, regularity and proper order converge in the term. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: it is not monetary metrology. [Q22-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: it is not a military formation. [Q22-D]

Examiner trap 22: Translate concepts without forcing later legal categories onto them.

Q23

23 Henotheism is useful only if it is treated as

- A. a Rigvedic self-declared church creed, as a direct material and social identity
- B. proof of strict monotheism, throughout every region and textual layer
- C. a bounded modern label for hymnic exaltation of one deity
- D. evidence of idol temples, without chronological or source qualification

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the term is a modern analytical category. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: plural deities remain present. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: selective exaltation is captured without claiming a formal creed. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the label does not establish temples or images. [Q23-D]

Examiner trap 23: Analytical terminology must not masquerade as indigenous self-description.

Q24

24 Which assumption should be rejected for Early Vedic religion?

- A. Fire ritual and offering mattered, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. Correct speech and metre mattered, as a complete territorial institution
- C. Priestly mediation mattered, without chronological or source qualification
- D. Monumental temples and idol institutions defined the corpus

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect as a rejection: fire and offering are central evidence. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect as a rejection: ritual speech and metre are significant. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect as a rejection: priests mediated sacrifice. [Q24-C]

- **D:** Correct: temple-image institutions cannot be assumed as the defining form. [Q24-D]

Examiner trap 24: Absence of a temple-centred baseline is not absence of sophisticated religion.

Q25

25 Horse and chariot references most securely indicate

- A. elite mobility, prestige and martial symbolism
- B. the number of horses in every household, without chronological or source qualification
- C. one pottery culture's language, as a direct material and social identity
- D. a territorial cavalry bureaucracy, throughout every region and textual layer

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: value and function are safer than population statistics. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: hymn frequency cannot produce a household census. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: objects do not identify speech unaided. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: a bureaucratic cavalry establishment is not demonstrated. [Q25-D]

Examiner trap 25: Textual prominence establishes salience, not quantitative prevalence.

Q26

26 In older Rigvedic contexts, *ayas* should be read as

- A. only wrought iron, without chronological or source qualification
- B. metal, generally within a copper-bronze horizon
- C. a named river, throughout every region and textual layer
- D. a tax on craftsmen, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: automatic iron translation collapses chronology. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: the broad metal sense preserves Early Vedic context. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: *ayas* is not hydronymy. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: no craft tax is encoded in the word. [Q26-D]

Examiner trap 26: Shyama *ayas* and major iron use belong chiefly to later comparison.

Q27

27 Which conclusion about funerary practice is safest?

- A. Only cremation ever occurred, as a direct material and social identity
- B. Only burial ever occurred, throughout every region and textual layer
- C. Cremation and burial traditions varied by layer and corpus
- D. Funerary hymns prove completed Upanishadic moksha doctrine

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: burial evidence prevents an exclusive claim. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: cremation traditions prevent the reverse exclusive claim. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: plurality and chronology are the defensible formulation. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: later systematic liberation doctrine cannot be projected backward. [Q27-D]

Examiner trap 27: Plural rites defeat universal statements based on one passage.

Q28

28 What can archaeology establish most securely for the Rigvedic problem?

- A. The spoken language of Cemetery H, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. The ethnicity of every PGW user, as a complete territorial institution
- C. The exact date of a hymn, without chronological or source qualification
- D. Material chronology, settlement, tools, diet and burial contexts

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: material assemblage alone cannot reveal speech. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: PGW is not an ethnic label. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: textual composition needs independent philology. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: these are archaeology's direct evidentiary strengths. [Q28-D]

Examiner trap 28: Correlation becomes error when an assemblage is turned into a people-name.

Q29

29 The Early-to-Later Vedic comparison is best framed as

- A. a gradual regional reweighting with important continuities
- B. an overnight replacement of all institutions, without chronological or source qualification
- C. a change from no farming to first farming, as a direct material and social identity
- D. a shift from equality to the first hierarchy, throughout every region and textual layer

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: direction and continuity are both preserved. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: long transitions are not instantaneous. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: agriculture was already present. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: differentiation existed in the earlier phase. [Q29-D]

Examiner trap 29: Binary contrasts exaggerate change by erasing the Early Vedic baseline.

Q30

30 The 2026 Q10 well-and-draught route should be handled by

- A. calling the provisional key official, without chronological or source qualification
- B. testing each supporting item against the two propositions
- C. treating sickles alone as proof of well lifting
- D. inferring a large canal state, as a complete territorial institution

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the locally held key is explicitly provisional. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: proposition-level matching controls the answer. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: cultivation tools do not prove the water-lifting mechanism. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the evidence is much narrower than a canal bureaucracy. [Q30-D]

Examiner trap 30: Objective questions require statement-by-statement evidentiary matching.

Q31

31 For the 2026 river question, the safest historical statement is

- A. Vitasta-Chenab is secure, as a direct material and social identity
- B. Asikni-Jhelum is secure, throughout every region and textual layer
- C. Parushni-Ravi is secure while Yavyavati-Beas remains key-sensitive
- D. all four pairs are secure, without chronological or source qualification

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Vitasta is Jhelum. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Asikni is Chenab. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: the secure pair is separated from the disputed/provisional-key issue. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: two pairs are plainly reversed and pair four needs caution. [Q31-D]

Examiner trap 31: Report a provisional key without converting a contested pair into canonical fact.

Q32

32 Which answer sequence is most defensible?

- A. List Sanskrit terms without argument, throughout every region and textual layer
- B. Begin with Later Vedic institutions, as a complete territorial institution
- C. Equate text, pottery and ethnicity, without chronological or source qualification
- D. define -> date -> locate -> explain mechanisms -> qualify -> compare

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: terminology without inference earns little analytical credit. [Q32-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: backward projection distorts the phase. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: independent evidence classes cannot be collapsed. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: the sequence produces an auditable historical argument. [Q32-D]

Examiner trap 32: An answer spine is a reasoning order, not a decorative catalogue.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AND KEY DISCIPLINE

The 2026 Set-A question wording is verified against the locally held paper. Its locally held answer key is explicitly **provisional, not an official final UPSC key**. The 2023 and 2024 Mains wording is verified; UPSC publishes no official model answer.

VERIFIED PRELIMS PYQ - 2026 GS-I SET A Q10

Question as printed (cleaned from the local OCR): Consider the following statements about the Rigvedic period: (I) Irrigation from wells allowed agriculture to expand away from flood plains and river margins into Punjab-Haryana plains with relatively accessible groundwater. (II) Draught-animal power was employed to draw water from wells. Which information supports the statements? (1) Rigvedic use of *ashma chakra* (stone pulley wheel) and *ahava* (strapped wooden pails) to draw water. (2) Rigvedic axes and sickles. (3) Pre-Rigvedic use of oxen for ploughing and pulling carts.

Option	Combination	Status
A	1 and 2 only	Does not connect draught power to statement II
B	1, 2 and 3	Tool evidence 2 does not specifically establish either proposition
C	1 and 3 only	LOCAL PROVISIONAL KEY
D	3 only	Omits direct water-lifting evidence 1

Answer status: C under the locally held provisional Series-A key; **not officially final.**

Elimination: Item 1 directly supports well lifting; item 3 supports the history of draught power. Axes and sickles establish cultivation and woodworking, not the specified water-lifting propositions.

Trap: The question asks which information supports the statements, not which objects merely occur in the period.

VERIFIED PRELIMS PYQ - 2026 GS-I SET A Q15

Question as printed: Which pairs of ancient and modern river names are correctly matched? (1) Vitasta-Chenab, (2) Asikni-Jhelum, (3) Parushni-Ravi, (4) Yavyavati-Beas.

Option	Combination	Status
A	1 and 2	Both standard pairs are reversed
B	3 and 4	LOCAL PROVISIONAL KEY; pair 4 remains textually contentious
C	3 only	Secure historical pair without endorsing the disputed fourth pair
D	4 only	Omits secure Parushni-Ravi

Key discipline: The locally held provisional Series-A key records **B**. Standard textbook geography securely gives Vitasta-Jhelum, Asikni-Chenab, Parushni-Ravi and Vipasha-Beas; it does not justify converting Yavyavati-Beas into an unqualified canonical fact. Preserve the provisional key as a key record and the river-identification caution as historical analysis.

Trap: Official question wording, provisional coaching key and independently secure historical identification are three different evidentiary claims.

VERIFIED PRELIMS PYQ - 2026 GS-I SET A Q20

Question as printed: In which one among the following texts does the term *kshetra-patni* ('mistress of the field') originate?

Option	Text	Status
A	Rigveda	Distinguish masculine <i>kshetra-pati</i> in Rig Veda 4.57
B	Atharvaveda	LOCAL PROVISIONAL KEY
C	Ashtadhyayi	Later grammatical text
D	Arthashastra	Later statecraft text

Answer status: B under the locally held provisional Series-A key; **not officially final**. The narrow lexical route is retained without inventing a hymn citation.

SOLVED MAINS PYQ - 2023 GS-I Q11

Verified wording: What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society? (250 words, 15 marks.)

Model route: Begin with layered Vedic sources; separate Rigvedic kin-based agro-pastoral society from later agrarian-territorial elaboration. Use jana, vis, rajan, cattle, agriculture, patriliney and emerging varna for society; use Indra, Agni, Varuna, rta, yajna and later ritual-philosophical expansion for religion. Persistence must mean transformed repertoire-chanting, fire ritual, kin idioms and hierarchy-rather than unchanged institutions. Constitutional equality, reform, regional histories and new devotional forms qualify every continuity.

Why this earns marks: It answers both clauses, distinguishes the two Vedic phases and treats continuity as historically transformed.

SOLVED MAINS PYQ - 2024 GS-I Q1

Verified wording: Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period. (150 words, 10 marks.)

Model answer: Rigvedic society was organised mainly through jana, vis and mobile or semi-settled grama, with cattle-centred prestige, cultivation, crafts and chiefly redistribution. Later Vedic developments shifted toward Kuru-Panchala and the upper Ganga, more stable plough agriculture, larger surplus and stronger territorial attachment. Occupational differentiation expanded, while Brahmana-Rajanya privilege and four-varna ideology hardened beyond the later-layer Purusha formulation. Patriliney, gotra and household authority sharpened, although women's work and learning remained regionally variable. Bali and kingship became more regular and coercive, yet cattle, kinship, assemblies and sacrifice continued. Thus society and economy were gradually agrarianised, territorialised and stratified rather than abruptly replaced; textual norms and PGW archaeology must still be correlated cautiously. (117 words)

Why this earns marks: It uses change verbs, named terms, continuity and an archaeological-source limit within the 150-word ceiling.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain why the Rig Veda is indispensable yet limited as a source for the Early Vedic age. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (124 words):

The Rig Veda is indispensable because its ten mandalas preserve the earliest extensive Vedic evidence for language, ritual, rivers, cattle wealth, kin units, chiefs and conflict. Books 2-7 provide a conventional older family-book baseline, allowing broad reconstruction of a north-western, cattle-valuing and kin-ordered society. Yet the corpus is orally transmitted ritual poetry, not a census or political chronicle. Praise, metaphor and priestly patronage privilege elite concerns, while composition, arrangement and later manuscript survival belong to different dates. Therefore a term such as rajan or grama must be read in its hymn and layer, compared with repeated usage and tested against independently dated archaeology. The text yields strong patterns, but not exact population statistics, uniform institutions or a one-to-one map of language and material culture.

Demand decoding: Identify the directive, confine the period, organise dimensions and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Every major claim uses a named term, hymn, river, institution or archaeological horizon and states what it cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: The model directly answers the demand, uses examinable evidence, explains mechanism and preserves chronology, genre and scale limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Why should the Rigvedic rajan be understood as a chief rather than a mature territorial monarch? (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (123 words):

The Rigvedic rajan exercised genuine authority as protector, war leader, ritual patron and distributor of movable wealth. The Sudas tradition and the roles of purohita, senani and gramani show military, priestly and group leadership around the chief. However, the political community was framed mainly through jana, vis, grama and kula-contextual units of people and kin-rather than fixed provinces. Sabha, samiti and vidatha also indicate collective arenas that could support or limit chiefly action. Bali was offering or tribute, not securely an assessed land tax, and no permanent bureaucracy, standing army or regular territorial revenue system is demonstrated. Thus "chiefship" captures hierarchy, patronage and command without denying government; "territorial monarchy" overstates institutions that become clearer only through the uneven Later Vedic transition.

Demand decoding: Identify the directive, confine the period, organise dimensions and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Every major claim uses a named term, hymn, river, institution or archaeological horizon and states what it cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: The model directly answers the demand, uses examinable evidence, explains mechanism and preserves chronology, genre and scale limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: "Rigvedic society was pastoral but not purely pastoral." Discuss. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (162 words):

Cattle occupied the centre of Rigvedic elite value. Gomat signified wealth in cattle, while gavishti joined cattle-search or raid with conflict. Cows, oxen and horses supplied food, traction, mobility, prestige, ritual gifts and booty. This evidence justifies "pastoral predominance" and helps explain pasture disputes, mobile groups and chiefly redistribution.

Agriculture was nevertheless present. Kshetra, plough-related vocabulary, sowing, harvesting and threshing indicate cultivation; yava is the clearest cereal reference. Wells, channels and draught oxen show water management and traction. Carpentry, chariot work, weaving, leather work, pottery and metalwork further reveal mixed production. Dana, dakshina, bali and barter circulated livestock, produce and crafted goods.

The qualification is essential. Ritual poetry magnifies cattle and chiefly gifts, so textual frequency is not an economic census. Conversely, agricultural terms do not establish the iron-assisted surplus, regular revenue or territorial state associated more strongly with later developments. The most defensible model is therefore a cattle-centred agro-pastoral economy with household crafts and redistributive exchange, varying by region and mobility.

Demand decoding: Identify the directive, confine the period, organise dimensions and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Every major claim uses a named term, hymn, river, institution or archaeological horizon and states what it cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: The model directly answers the demand, uses examinable evidence, explains mechanism and preserves chronology, genre and scale limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Assess social differentiation and the position of women in the Early Vedic age without projecting later norms backwards. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (172 words):

Early Vedic society was neither classless nor already organised through a rigid later caste system. Chiefs, priests, warriors, producers, artisans, dependants and captives occupied unequal positions. Varna language marked order or boundary, while the Purusha Sukta, Rig Veda 10.90, articulated Brahmana, Rajanya, Vaishya and Shudra. Its generally later Book 10 location makes it evidence of emerging ideological systematisation, not proof of hereditary jati closure throughout the older family books.

Households combined herding, cultivation, craft and ritual. Patrilineal tendencies, son preference and male-centred authority indicate patriarchy. Yet women appear as household and ritual actors, and traditions associate Ghosha, Apala, Lopamudra and Vishvavara with female poetic voices. Such visibility qualifies any claim of total exclusion but cannot establish universal education, assembly membership or equality. Marriage formed households and alliances; monogamy may have been common, elite polygyny existed, and scattered references to widow or levirate-like practices remain debated.

Thus differentiation and patriarchy were real but still historically variable. Layered elite poetry requires rejecting both romantic egalitarianism and the backward projection of later prescriptive rigidity.

Demand decoding: Identify the directive, confine the period, organise dimensions and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Every major claim uses a named term, hymn, river, institution or archaeological horizon and states what it cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: The model directly answers the demand, uses examinable evidence, explains mechanism and preserves chronology, genre and scale limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Examine how Rigvedic religion expressed the economic and political world of Early Vedic society. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (182 words):

Rigvedic religion organised relations among nature, conflict, order, patronage and exchange. Indra's association with storm, rain and victory suited a cattle-valuing martial world; Agni mediated offerings; Varuna guarded rta, the vocabulary of truth and cosmic-ritual regularity; Soma joined ritual drink, inspiration and divine power; Ushas represented renewal.

Yajna was also a social mechanism. A patron offered through priests and sought protection, rain, offspring or victory. Dana and dakshina redistributed cattle and valuables, enhanced chiefly generosity and sustained poet-priest lineages. Correct speech, metre and performance therefore converted economic resources into ritual authority. The Sudas victory tradition similarly shows warfare remembered through priestly praise and patronage.

This connection should not be overstated. Hymn frequency reflects liturgy and patrons, not a survey of every household's belief. Henotheism is only a modern label for exalting one deity within a hymn, not a Rigvedic creed of strict monotheism. Monumental temples, image-centred institutions and the fully elaborated Later Vedic royal-sacrifice system cannot be projected backward. Rigvedic religion expressed and legitimised order, reciprocity, protection and prestige, while remaining a plural, layered ritual-poetic world rather than a territorial state church.

Demand decoding: Identify the directive, confine the period, organise dimensions and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Every major claim uses a named term, hymn, river, institution or archaeological horizon and states what it cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: The model directly answers the demand, uses examinable evidence, explains mechanism and preserves chronology, genre and scale limits.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Analyse the relationship between Rigvedic textual evidence and archaeology, and explain the Early-to-Later Vedic transition. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (185 words):

The Rig Veda directly supplies language, ritual, river names, cattle values, kin terms, chiefship and remembered conflict. Archaeology directly supplies settlement, diet, tools, metals, vehicles, burials and chronology. The two sources become useful together only when date, region and evidentiary scale match.

Late Harappan and Cemetery H contexts show continuity and regional transformation after urban decline; Swat sequences reveal varied frontier contacts; OCP and copper-hoard associations are uneven. None independently identifies Vedic Sanskrit speakers. PGW belongs mainly to Later Vedic and early Iron Age comparison, not the material identity of older hymns. Likewise, ashva and ratha vocabulary shows elite salience, while equid remains and vehicles require separate species, context and technological identification; ayas cannot automatically be translated as iron.

Across the transition, the centre moved from Sapta-Sindhu toward Kuru-Panchala and the upper Ganga. Cultivation and settlement intensified, kingship became more territorial, exaction and ritual elaborated, and varna-patriarchal hierarchy sharpened. Yet cattle, kinship, assemblies and sacrifice persisted in altered settings. The transition was therefore gradual, regional and uneven: archaeology tests material change, while layered texts explain institutions and values, but neither permits a one-to-one ethnic map.

Demand decoding: Identify the directive, confine the period, organise dimensions and end with a graded source-aware verdict.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: Every major claim uses a named term, hymn, river, institution or archaeological horizon and states what it cannot prove.

Why this earns marks: The model directly answers the demand, uses examinable evidence, explains mechanism and preserves chronology, genre and scale limits.